China may have been a particular beneficiary of the geopolitics of the last century. But the fact remains that the shortfalls on the American account today cannot be readily filled by the growth of China's capabilities. Some of that reflects from the sheer spread of the US and its extensive grip on the international order. But there is also the crucial difference in the very nature of the two polities.

The US has prided itself on its universalism and consciously promoted these traits. China, in contrast, considers itself singular and its globalization is not readily converted into universalization. Each will play to its strengths. In an interesting way, the two will be a study in contrasts. One will make the most of its openness and diversity while building on its unique ability to attract global talent; the other has developed formidable strengths by leveraging the world, even while developing autonomous capabilities through extraordinary fusion. Paradoxically, a challenge that awaits them both is to ensure that these very qualities are not exploited by the other.

What is relevant for our purpose is the lessening convergence in their respective world views. And what that will lead to is a period of uncertainty, limitations and frictions in world affairs. This will be most evident on global connects like supply chains and data flows as well as challenges like maritime security, pandemics and terrorism. After all, we have a situation where not just the distribution of power has undergone a change, but along with it the characteristics of those who will now wield greater influence. Quite apart from their ability to work together or not, how they view enlightened self-interest and how much that would propel them to contribute to safeguarding the global commons are the questions that await answers.

It is not just eastwards in the Indo-Pacific that India is witnessing a radically different situation. Towards the West, the politics of our proximate region is also undergoing a transformation with the American exit from Afghanistan. Diplomats in the UN may have articulated the concerns of the international community in terms of terrorism and radicalization, treatment of women and minorities, freedom to travel and inclusive governance. But strategists with an understanding of the region would also be forced to recognize how open-ended its prospects have become. The balance of values, ideologies and interests are being carefully weighed by all relevant parties.